

The autumn of a golden generation

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Belgium enters the tournament with the strange feeling of a team that remains dangerous, but is no longer untouchable. For much of the last decade, Belgium travelled to major tournaments with the aura of a side whose moment was either arriving or overdue. The names were illustrious, the rankings were lofty and the expectations relentless. But time has altered the shape of that story. The golden generation has thinned, the certainties have faded, and what remains is a team trying to prove that its window has not fully closed.

In Group G, Belgium is still the side to beat. But this is not a group it can glide through on reputation alone. Egypt brings Mohamed Salah and an increasingly potent attacking edge through Omar Marmoush. Iran brings tournament experience, structure and stubborn resistance. New Zealand brings little pressure and the freedom that comes with the lack of expectations. For

Belgium, the task appears simple only on paper: win the group, avoid a more complicated route, and demonstrate that its authority has not entirely disappeared.

Rudi Garcia has Kevin De Bruyne, Romelu Lukaku, Thibaut Courtois and Axel Witsel at his disposal, but he also has Jeremy Doku, Amadou Onana, Charles De Ketelaere and Arthur Theate. That blend gives Belgium quality, but also raises questions about rhythm, age and defensive balance. The attacking options are strong enough to win the group, but Belgium's tournament will depend on whether it can defend transitions and manage games when De Bruyne is denied time and space.

Its path, at least during the group stage, appears manageable. Belgium opens against Egypt in Seattle on June 15, faces Iran in Los Angeles on June 21 and closes against New Zealand in Vancouver on June 26. The geography is kinder than that of most groups, with all its matches



BELGIUM

FIFA Ranking: 9

Appearances: 14

Best finish: Third place (2018)

Matches: 51

Wins: 21

Draws: 10

Losses: 20

Goals For: 69

Goals Against: 74

Highest scorer in the squad
Romelu Lukaku (89 goals)



EGYPT

FIFA Ranking: 28

Appearances: 3

Best finish: Group stage (1934)

Matches: 7

Wins: 0

Draws: 2

Losses: 5

Goals For: 5

Goals Against: 12

Highest scorer in the squad
Mohamed Salah (67 goals)

